

Toward Family-Governed AI for Early Childhood Service Transitions

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The transition from Early Intervention services under the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA) could be overwhelming for families. This paper examines how parents find, understand, compare, and use information during the transition from an Individualized Family Service Plan (IFSP) to an Individualized Education Program (IEP). A structured literature synthesis of 23 peer-reviewed articles, supplemented by an IDEA policy source, was conducted. The findings show that families' information needs change throughout the transition, while important information is often distributed among professionals, documents, and institutions. As a result, parents undertake substantial information-gathering, coordination, and advocacy work, which can be especially difficult for families facing linguistic, geographic, cultural, or resource-related barriers. Drawing on these findings, we introduce the *Family-Governed Transition Navigator* as a conceptual design for a shared AI-supported workspace involving families, early-intervention providers, school personnel, and advocates. The concept explores how AI might help users track transition activities, understand documents in plain language, record family priorities, coordinate tasks, and prepare for meetings. Different stakeholders could access information according to their roles, while families would review and approve what is shared. The proposed design aims to support shared understanding, make coordination work visible, and preserve family control over information.

CCS Concepts: • **Human-Centered Computing** → **Empirical studies in HCI**.

Additional Key Words and Phrases: IFSP-to-IEP Transition, Caregiver Information Navigation, Information Needs, Family-Centered Practices, Educational Decision-Making, Early Childhood Special Education

1 Introduction

The Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA) establishes two connected service systems. Part C provides family-centered early intervention services to eligible infants and toddlers from birth through age two through an Individualized Family Service Plan (IFSP), which identifies developmental outcomes and supports for the child and family. Part B provides special education and related services to eligible children ages three through twenty-one through an Individualized Education Program (IEP), which focuses on educational goals and services. As a child approaches age three, Part C must include a transition plan in the IFSP at least 90 days before the child's third birthday and coordinate with the local school district for children potentially eligible for Part B. The district then conducts a separate eligibility evaluation and, if the child qualifies, develops and implements an IEP by the third birthday [16]. For families, this shift is not only a change in service plans; it also redistributes responsibility for interpreting information, coordinating with professionals, and making decisions about the child's educational support.

Although federal regulations define transition procedures, eligibility timelines, and coordination requirements, the IFSP-to-IEP transition is often experienced by families as complex, fragmented, and difficult to interpret. Parents must understand new terminology, evaluation reports, eligibility decisions, procedural safeguards, service options, and the roles of multiple professionals across early intervention and school-based systems. Prior studies have documented parent stress, uncertainty, communication barriers, service discontinuity, and inequities during this transition. For example, rural families may face additional challenges related to service access, geographic distance, and limited institutional resources [9]. Douglas et al. found that caregivers frequently reported confusion about procedural expectations, differences between systems, and uncertainty about future services [10]. Similarly, Batz and Yadav described how parents

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Table 1. Background literature on the IFSP-to-IEP transition

Topic	Citations	Description
The IFSP-to-IEP Transition	[2, 3, 7, 13, 15]	At about age three, children move from IDEA Part C/IFSP services to Part B/IEP preschool special education. Although planning, evaluation, eligibility, and coordination procedures are defined, families encounter different goals, terminology, documents, and professional expectations. They report uncertainty about timelines and services and difficulty understanding rules, evaluations, safeguards, and meetings, highlighting the need for earlier preparation, clearer communication, and stronger coordination.
Family-Centered Practices and Communication	[2, 7, 9, 12]	Family-centered practice positions families as partners in decision-making and service planning. Families value timely, transparent communication about procedures, eligibility, services, and rights, but report inconsistency, limited participation, and fragmented information. Language and cross-system barriers particularly affect culturally and linguistically diverse families, making trust, respect, and ongoing family-professional communication important.
Parent Information Navigation and Institutional Complexity	[2, 7–9, 11, 12, 20]	Families gather and reconcile information across providers, evaluators, schools, administrators, documents, and policies. This often-invisible work includes organizing records, recalling communication, preparing questions, contacting professionals, and monitoring actions. Navigation is further limited by language and cultural barriers, rural distance and service shortages, limited culturally responsive resources, and complex official materials. Parents compensate through multiple sources, professional relationships, parent networks, and independent research.

often piece together fragmented information from professionals, service coordinators, schools, and informal support networks in order to understand the transition process [2]. Consequently, parents perform substantial information and coordination work, including locating resources, comparing information, preparing for meetings, preserving records, and communicating across institutional boundaries.

In this paper, we conduct a literature review and organize the related literature in five areas. (1) parents' changing information needs before, during, and after the transition; (2) the formal and informal information sources parents rely on; (3) barriers that affect information access, comprehension, and use; (4) strategies parents use to navigate information and advocate for services; and (5) how information navigation shapes parent participation, satisfaction, and decision-making during the transition process. Together, these areas reveal the temporal, relational, and institutional dimensions of information navigation, as well as the conditions that make navigation more difficult for some families than others. Building on these findings, this paper considers how family-centered AI might respond to the information-navigation challenges families experience during the IFSP-to-IEP transition. Rather than treating AI as an individual parent-facing chatbot, we propose an AI solution that could help families and professionals make sense of information together, make coordination and caregiving work more visible, and give families ongoing control over how their information is interpreted, stored, and shared across institutional boundaries. To illustrate these possibilities, the paper introduces the Family-Governed Transition Navigator as a conceptual direction for future AI support. The implications are organized around three areas: supporting family connection, recognizing and coordinating information and caregiving labor, and enabling continuous family governance. The Navigator is not an implemented or evaluated system; instead, it translates the literature findings into considerations for future participatory design with families and professionals.

2 Methodology

This study employed a structured literature synthesis across different scientific databases (that includes Google Scholar, ERIC, and Scopus) to identify recurring patterns in how parents access, interpret, coordinate, and use information during the IFSP-to-IEP transition. Peer-reviewed English-language studies were included when they addressed the U.S. transition from IDEA Part C early intervention/IFSP services to Part B preschool special education/IEP services and reported on parent or caregiver experiences, information needs, communication, participation, advocacy, or service coordination. Studies not focused on the Part C-to-Part B transition, family perspectives, or the U.S. IDEA context, as well as those focused only on child outcomes, clinical interventions, or professional training, were excluded. Table 1 summarizes the main areas of background literature that informed this review, including their focus, supporting

citations, and relevance to the IFSP-to-IEP transition. The synthesis was intended to support conceptual understanding and design development rather than to provide an exhaustive systematic review.

3 Findings

Two researchers independently applied an inductive, data-driven thematic analysis—coding the material, comparing codes, and reaching consensus through iterative discussion—which yielded five recurring patterns across the studies (see Table 2).

Table 2. Themes identified through the literature synthesis

Theme	Citations	Description
Temporal Dimension	[2, 8, 10, 12, 17]	Information needs change across the transition. Beforehand, families need guidance on timelines, eligibility, evaluations, and future services; during meetings, they need help interpreting results, safeguards, and IFSP-to-IEP goals; afterward, they need information about service delivery and monitoring. Unclear or delayed information causes confusion, making navigation an ongoing process that may benefit from timely, stage-appropriate guidance.
Information-Ecology Dimension	[2, 7–9, 11, 12]	Information is distributed across professionals, reports, procedural documents, websites, parent networks, and advocacy organizations. Families must gather, compare, and reconcile these sources before making decisions. State resources vary, and safeguard notices may be difficult to understand. Parents therefore become information coordinators, suggesting value in a future workspace that connects sources while preserving their context.
Information Barriers	[4, 7, 9, 20]	The move to school-based special education introduces unfamiliar terminology, eligibility rules, documents, meetings, and professional roles. Language barriers and unequal participation affect culturally and linguistically diverse families, while rural families face distance, service shortages, and fewer supports. Access is also shaped by culture, socioeconomic conditions, and prior knowledge. AI might clarify language and processes without replacing professional expertise or reinforcing inequity.
Information Navigation as Advocacy Work	[5, 6, 18, 19]	Fragmented or technical information leads parents to prepare questions, document concerns, seek clarification, consult other parents, attend training, and build professional relationships. Advocacy often responds to gaps in institutional support, but the burden is unequal because families differ in time, confidence, language access, and institutional knowledge. AI might assist with organization, meeting preparation, documentation, and coordination while leaving decisions with families.
Consequences of Information Navigation	[14, 21–23]	The ability to understand and use information affects family participation, preparedness, satisfaction, advocacy, and decision-making. Meaningful involvement also depends on clear communication, partnership, meeting preparation, and opportunities to contribute. These findings motivate three design directions: supporting shared understanding, making coordination responsibilities visible, and allowing families to review, correct, approve, and control how information is interpreted and shared.

4 Discussion and Design Implications

This synthesis reframes the IFSP-to-IEP transition as an ongoing information-navigation process rather than a single administrative event. Parents must learn a new institutional system, interpret unfamiliar documents and terminology, understand their rights, communicate with multiple professionals, and make educational decisions. This work involves repeated cycles of seeking information, resolving uncertainty, comparing sources, preparing for meetings, coordinating responsibilities, and advocating for services. The proposed design implications are derived from these recurring patterns and represent a literature-grounded conceptual direction rather than an implemented system.

This work offers three contributions. First, it shifts attention from the formal transition event to the information work families perform before, during, and after it. Second, it demonstrates that information access and participation are closely connected: families cannot participate meaningfully when information is fragmented, delayed, difficult to understand, or inconsistently communicated. Third, it positions information navigation as an equity issue. Families with greater language access, institutional knowledge, professional trust, time, and advocacy resources may be better prepared to

navigate the process, while families experiencing structural barriers may face greater difficulty understanding and using information.

Taken together, these findings identify five design opportunities for family-centered AI during the transition. The proposed design is intended to provide ongoing guidance across the transition timeline, bring together information distributed across institutions, and reduce the burden of information management and coordination. It may also facilitate shared understanding between families and professionals while preserving family control over how information is interpreted, stored, and shared. In practice, features such as timeline tracking, document organization, plain-language explanations, comparisons of Part C and Part B services, question preparation, and communication histories can assist families throughout the process. Together, these functions are intended to complement—not replace—family-professional communication and offer assistance that is accessible, culturally responsive, transparent, and aligned with families’ information needs.

4.1 Proposed Design: The Family-Governed Transition Navigator

Building on the identified themes and literature-derived requirements, we propose the Family-Governed Transition Navigator—a conceptual AI-supported workspace that, as a design direction rather than a finished or evaluated system, helps families longitudinally navigate, understand, organize, coordinate, and manage the overwhelming IFSP-to-IEP transition. The designated system should include five main functions: (1) a Transition Action Map showing important dates, meetings, documents, and follow-up tasks; (2) a Document Explanation tool that explains IFSPs, evaluations, procedural safeguards, and draft IEPs in plain language while linking explanations to the original documents; (3) a Shared Family Priorities space where caregivers can record their concerns, questions, and observations about the child; (4) a Task Board showing who is responsible for each transition activity; and (5) a Privacy and Sharing Center that allows families to decide what information can be stored, corrected, or shared.

The design enables families to prepare together while honoring each member’s priorities. It could also make responsibilities visible, reduce the burden on a single caregiver, and give families control over information sharing. To support transparency, it would show sources, flag uncertainty, and allow families to correct AI-generated content. To enforce family-centered governance, any questions, advice, or meeting summaries created by the AI would remain drafts until the family reviews and approves them. Early-intervention providers could contribute transition dates, current goals, and relevant documents, while the school team could view the family-approved summary and respond to questions or action items. Although families and professionals would use the same platform, each stakeholder would have a different view based on their role. Families would have a private workspace for documents, concerns, questions, and family tasks. They could create and approve a transition summary containing the information they want to share.

Advancements on LLM-based agents has explored sustained, personalized support in contexts requiring continuity over time. Agentic AI approaches demonstrate how AI systems can support complex, goal-directed tasks [1], while MemoryBank shows how LLMs can store, retrieve, and update information from prior interactions [24]. Drawing on these capabilities, the Navigator could maintain a family-controlled memory of priorities, documents, meeting outcomes, and pending tasks, enabling context-aware guidance while keeping stored and shared information. We argue the AI agent could companion and grow with the family between transitions, so that the conversation, interaction, and generated data would be stored and further be used to provide support to the families. The AI agent can ingest best-practice recommendations from external experts, supporting communities or professionals—i.e., common challenges and/or experiences for families during the transition. It can then translate this guidance into family-centered advice, thereby improving communication between external expertise and the families’ needs.

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